

PHIL 1001: Ethics for the Digital Age



Moral Relativism



Week 03 Lecture A.

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Agenda

1. Preliminaries & Broad Relativism
2. The Argument from Moral Disagreement
3. Moral Relativism Stated as a Theory in NEB
4. A Consideration that Supports that Theory

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Part I Introductory & Preliminaries

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Moral Codes

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A **moral code** is a system of rules for behavior that a person or a social group might or might not accept at a given time.

- The code classifies actions as a being either:
[1] required, [2] forbidden or [3] optional / permitted.
- Typically such rules concern **interpersonal conduct** and prescribe the conditions under which it is appropriate to feel **guilt, shame, and indignation**.
- A moral code need **not** be **explicitly written down**.

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Agents (or “rational agents”)

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^{rational}
An agent is a being that is capable of deliberating about which action to perform in a given situation.

The agent of an action, x, is the agent who performed x.

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Moral Universalism

Other names sometimes used for similar theses:

Moral objectivism.

Moral absolutism.

Moral non-relativism.

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Moral Universalism

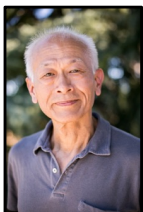
- (a) Among all the possible moral codes that could exist, **there is one (but only one) such code that is true** (i.e., that determines whether any given moral statement is true/false).
- (b) This one true moral code **applies to every agent** in the world.

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A Very Broad Characterization of Moral Relativism

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David Wong



"Moral relativism...often takes the form of [1] a denial that any single moral code has universal validity, and [2] an assertion that moral truth and justifiability are in some way relative to factors that are culturally and historically contingent."

Wong, David (1991). "Relativism." In Peter Singer (ed.) *A Companion to Ethics*. Malden, MA: Blackwell, p. 442.

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Gilbert Harman

"Moral right and wrong...are always relative to a choice of moral framework."

"What is morally right in relation to one moral framework can be morally wrong in relation to a different moral framework."

"And no moral framework is objectively privileged as the one true morality."

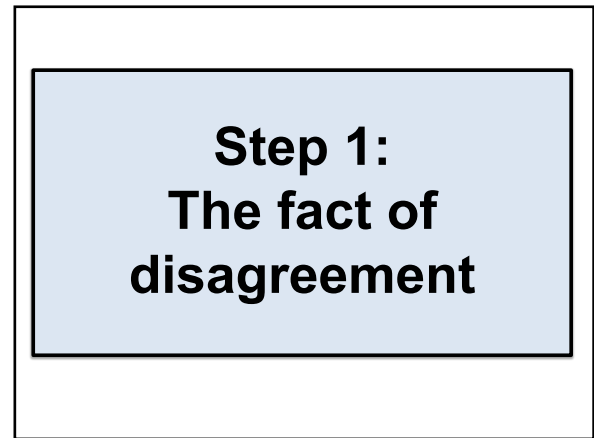


Harman, Gilbert (1996). "Moral Relativism". In Gilbert Harman and Judith Jarvis Thomson. *Moral Relativism and Moral Objectivity*. Malden, MA: Blackwell, p.3.

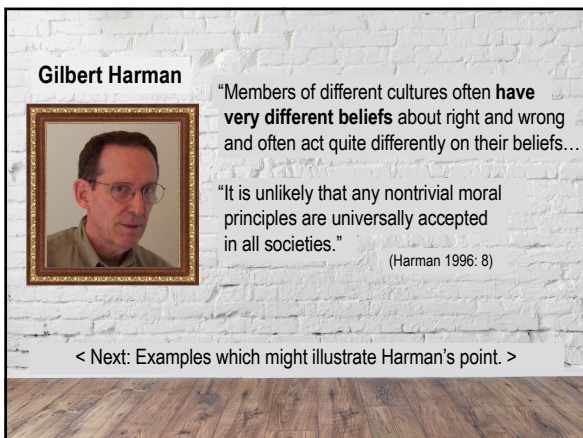
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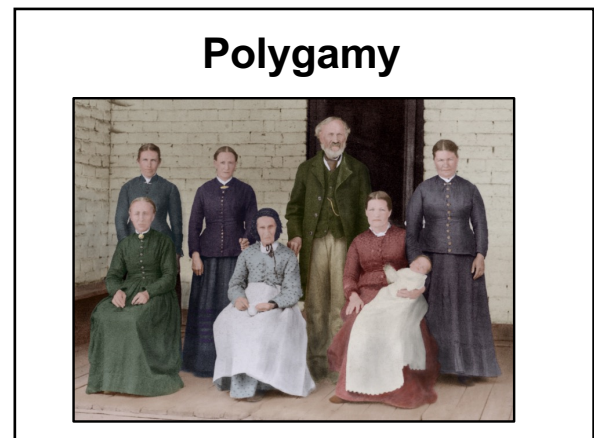
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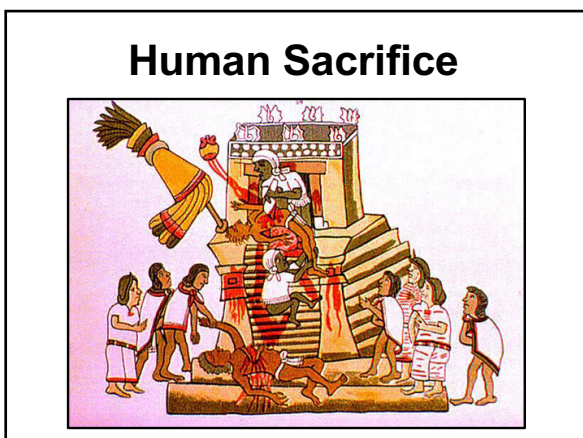
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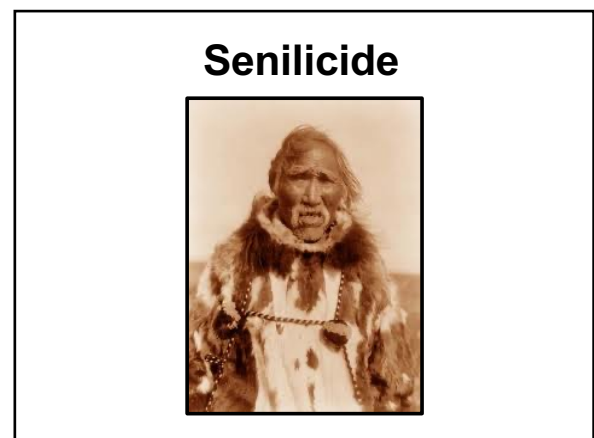
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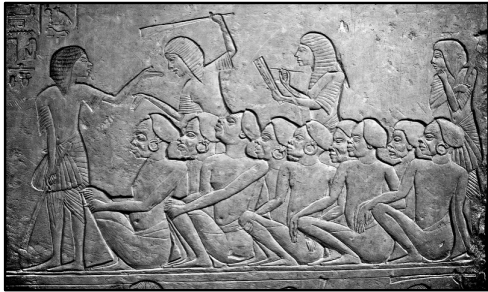


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Slavery



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Cannibalism



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Reverence for Cows



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Vegetarianism



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The argument from disagreement.

P1. Members of different cultures accept different moral codes.

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Step 2: Completing the Argument?

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The argument from disagreement, version 1.0.

P1. Members of different cultures accept different moral codes.

P2. If there were a single moral code that is uniquely true, applying to all rational agents, then members of different cultures **would not** accept different moral codes.

C. There is no single moral code that is uniquely true, applying to all rational agents (i.e. moral universalism is false.)

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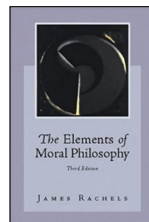
Question: How plausible is P2?:

P2. If there were a single moral code that is uniquely true, applying to all rational agents, then members of different cultures **would not** accept different moral codes.

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James Rachels

"The Challenge of Cultural Relativism".
In *The Elements of Moral Philosophy* 3rd Edition. Boston: McGraw Hill.



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"In some societies, people believe the earth is flat. In other societies, such as our own, people believe the earth is (roughly) spherical.



"Does it follow, from the mere fact that people disagree, that there is no 'objective truth' in geography? Of course not." (Rachels 1999: 24)

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**Step 2, take 2:
A "do-over" for the
argument!**

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The argument from disagreement, Version 2.0.

P1. Members of different cultures accept different moral codes.

P2'. If members of different cultures accept different moral codes, then this fact is **best explained** by the fact that no single moral code is uniquely true, applying to all rational agents.

C'. (Probably) There is no single moral code that is uniquely true, applying to all rational agents.

Compare with Wong (1991: 445-447) & Harman (1996: 8-14)

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Can P2' be given some support?

P2'. If members of different cultures accept different moral codes, then this fact is **best explained** by the fact that no single moral code is uniquely true, applying to all rational agents.



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J. L. Mackie (1977) *Ethics: Inventing Right & Wrong*



"...the actual variation in the moral codes are more readily explained by the hypothesis that **they reflect ways of life** [rather] than that **they express perceptions**, most of them seriously inadequate and badly distorted, of objective values."

Mackie (1977: 37).

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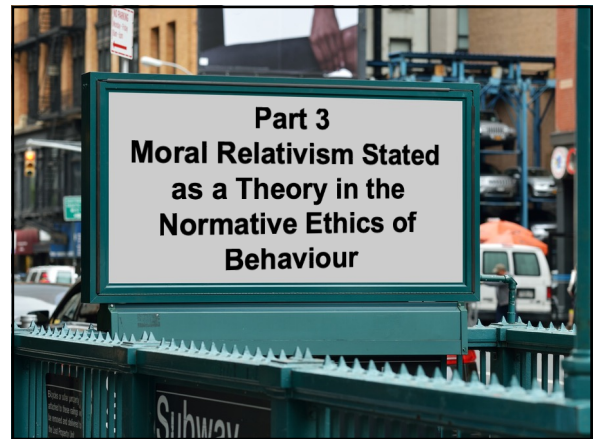
Section 3.

Evaluation of the argument
from disagreement

(Let's save this for next lecture!)

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Part 3 Moral Relativism Stated as a Theory in the Normative Ethics of Behaviour



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A Specific Version Moral Relativism Stated:

Cultural Relativism

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CR: an act-token, x, is morally right if and only if x is permitted the moral code that is accepted by the society to which the agent of x belongs.

Clarification:

- An **act-token** is a single agent's specific action that occurs only once, at a specific moment in time.
- An **act-type** is a *kind* of action: an act-type can be performed by indefinitely many agents at indefinitely many times.

• Al's lying at 12PM on May 1, 2019.
• Beth's lying at 6PM on Sept. 14, 1986. } two tokens of the same type.

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Understanding CR: CR Applied to an example

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The act? → Eating a bacon double cheeseburger.
 The agent? → Sally
 Agent's society? → United States of America
 Does the m. code accepted by agent's society permit the act? → Yes!



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The act? → Eating a bacon double cheeseburger.
 The agent? → Reşit
 Agent's society? → Türkiye
 Does the m. code accepted by agent's society permit the act? → No!



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Part 4
A Consideration
That Supports CR



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One Criterion (of several) for Evaluating Moral Theories:

Internal Support

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"A moral theory whose principles, together with relevant factual information, **logically imply** our considered moral beliefs **receives support**...from those beliefs.

(Timmons 2002: 15).

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In many cases, there really is something off about thinking someone acted wrongly in cases where they do something that **conforms** to the moral code of **their society**, even though it **conflicts** with the moral code of **your society**:

Some examples:

- (a) Avuncular parenting.
- (b) Public nudity.
- (c) Marriage between (e.g.) cousins?

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